Don't Trash That Pumpkin: Give It a Second Life

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Every fall, tens of millions of pumpkins appear on porches across the United States. Some become jack-o'-lanterns. Others are just decorations. After Halloween, most people think the pumpkin's job is done.

But throwing them away has a big hidden cost. Experts estimate over one billion pounds end up in United States **landfills** each year, more than 80 percent of the 1.3 billion pounds bought. In the United Kingdom, about 55 percent of 39 million pumpkins bought go uneaten, worth about $37 million.

When pumpkins rot in **landfills**, they release **methane**, a gas that traps much more heat than **carbon dioxide** over a shorter time. So a simple decoration can add to climate change.

Luckily, there is an easy fix. Roast the seeds for a snack, or turn the **flesh** into soup, **puree**, or pie. Donate pumpkins to farms or zoos for animal feed. If one is too old to eat or donate, bury it in your yard to feed the soil. That small choice, across millions of homes, can cut waste and help our environment.

Word Treasure

landfills -- A landfill is a large place where trash is buried in the ground.

methane -- Methane is a gas that traps heat in the air.

carbon dioxide -- Carbon dioxide is a gas in the air that can trap heat.

puree -- Puree is food that has been mashed until it is soft and smooth.

flesh -- The flesh of a pumpkin is the soft orange part inside it.

Background you need

A pumpkin is a big orange fruit that grows on a vine in the fall and is often carved into a jack-o'-lantern or used as a decoration for Halloween.

When food is thrown away, it goes to a landfill, a place where trash is buried, and as it rots there it can release methane, a gas that traps heat and adds to climate change.

That is why people look for other uses for old pumpkins, such as cooking them, feeding them to animals, or burying them in soil where they can break down and feed plants.

Break it down

WHO: People across the United States and the United Kingdom who buy pumpkins each fall
WHAT: Finding new uses for pumpkins after Halloween instead of throwing them away
WHERE: On porches across the United States, in homes and yards, and in landfills in the United States
WHY: Because pumpkins rotting in landfills release methane, a gas that traps much more heat than carbon dioxide, and reusing them can cut waste and help the environment

Why it matters

After Halloween, you can turn your own pumpkin into a snack or soup, or bury it to feed the soil, instead of letting it add to climate-changing waste.

Test what you remember

1. **What gas is released when pumpkins rot in landfills?**
   - (A) Nitrogen
   - (B) Oxygen
   - (C) Helium
   - (D) Methane
2. **According to experts, about how many pounds of pumpkins end up in United States landfills each year?**
   - (A) About 39 million pounds
   - (B) Less than 100 million pounds
   - (C) Over one billion pounds
   - (D) About 500 million pounds
3. **In the United Kingdom, about what share of the 39 million pumpkins bought go uneaten?**
   - (A) About 55 percent
   - (B) About 25 percent
   - (C) About 10 percent
   - (D) About 80 percent
4. **What can you do with pumpkin seeds?**
   - (A) Roast them for a snack
   - (B) Bury them in a landfill
   - (C) Donate them to a zoo
   - (D) Turn them into pie
5. **What can pumpkin flesh be turned into?**
   - (A) Soup, puree, or pie
   - (B) Animal feed only
   - (C) Methane gas
   - (D) A jack-o'-lantern
6. **If a pumpkin is too old to eat or donate, what can you do with it?**
   - (A) Roast its seeds
   - (B) Throw it in a landfill
   - (C) Bury it in your yard to feed the soil
   - (D) Leave it on the porch

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: C 3: A 4: A 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):